

r/aiwars

I don't understand the energy consumption argument against AI

Posted by u/OneNerdPower • 0 points • 45 comments

AI obviously saves energy.

Generating a few images using an AI model will use less energy than a digital artist using Photoshop for hours.

Comments

u/alwayslate187 • 1 points • 2026-02-11 02:13 UTC

Here is an article (in interview format) about this topic

[<https://iee.psu.edu/news/blog/why-ai-uses-so-much-energy-and-what-we-can-do-about-it>]
(<https://iee.psu.edu/news/blog/why-ai-uses-so-much-energy-and-what-we-can-do-about-it>)

u/AnimatorImportant665 • 1 points • 2026-02-07 18:47 UTC

The real issue is not the AI models or use of AI. The issue is how large companies decide to power their infrastructure.

<https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/05/20/1116327/ai-energy-usage-climate-footprint-big-tech/>
Quote:

That means data centers can't rely on intermittent technologies like wind and solar power, and on average, they tend to use dirtier electricity. One preprint study from Harvard's T.H. Chan School of Public Health found that the carbon intensity of electricity used by data centers was 48% higher than the US average. Part of the reason is that data centers currently happen to be clustered in places that have dirtier grids on average, like the coal-heavy grid in the mid-Atlantic region that includes Virginia, West Virginia, and Pennsylvania. They also run constantly, including when cleaner sources may not be available.

u/AnimatorImportant665 • 1 points • 2026-02-07 18:20 UTC

<https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/05/20/1116327/ai-energy-usage-climate-footprint-big-tech/>

The new model uses more than 30 times more energy on each 5-second video: about 3.4 million joules, more than 700 times the energy required to generate a high-quality image. This is equivalent to riding 38 miles on an e-bike, or running a microwave for over an hour.